

Lesson 7: “The First Principles and Ordinances of the Gospel” (See [Class Member Study Guide](#))

Purpose: To help us understand and seek the blessings of the first principles and ordinances of the gospel: faith in the Lord Jesus Christ, repentance, baptism, and confirmation.

1. Faith in the Lord Jesus Christ is the first principle of the gospel.

What are some reasons we must center our faith in Jesus Christ?

How can we strengthen our faith in Christ? †1. President David O. McKay †2. Richard Holzapfel (S.L. Temple)

- D&C 19:23 “Learn of me, and ... walk in the meekness of my Spirit”. Christ is meek.
- Ether 12:27 “If men come unto me, I will show unto them their weakness... that they may be humble”.
- Moro. 7:43-44 We “cannot have faith and hope, save [we] shall be meek, and lowly of heart.”
- D&C 88:118 “And as all have not faith, seek ye diligently and teach one another words of wisdom”.
- Alma 32:27 Arouse “your faculties, even to an experiment upon my words, and exercise a particle of faith”.
- D&C 128:21 God “giving line upon line, precept upon precept; here a little, and there a little”.

How can faith in Christ strengthen our relationships with others?

- D&C 8:10 What can we accomplish *without* faith in Christ?
- Moroni 7:33 What can we accomplish *with* faith in Christ?

2. Through sincere repentance, we can partake of the blessings of the Atonement.

†3. Repentance—Lesson Manual

- D&C 58:42-43 “By this ye may know if a man repenteth of his sins”.

†4. President Ezra Taft Benson †5. Elder Neal A. Maxwell

- D&C 18:11-13 The “Lord your Redeemer suffered ... that all men might repent and come unto him.”
- D&C 19:16-19; 2 Nephi 2:6-9; Alma 7:14

What are some reasons that faith in Jesus Christ is necessary for us to truly repent?

What are some Consequences of Not Repenting? See D&C 1:33; D&C 19:17-18; D&C 29:17.

What are some Blessings of True Repentance? See D&C 1:32; D&C 58:42; D&C 109:53.

How can we become more repentant?

How can we overcome pride, discouragement, complacency, or anything that may block our repentance?

3. Baptism is an essential ordinance.

†6. Baptism—Lesson Manual

- D&C 18:22; 49:13-14 What are the purposes of baptism?
- D&C 20:37 What qualifications must we meet to retain the blessings of baptism?
- Mosiah 18:8-10 What covenants did we make and must renew, to retain the blessings of baptism?
- D&C 76:51; John 3:3-5; Romans 6:3-4 What does baptism symbolize?
- D&C 22 Why is it necessary to be baptized by one who has the proper authority? By immersion? (D&C 20:72-74) And not before the age of accountability? (D&C 20:71; 29:46-47; 68:25; Moro. 8:9-12)

4. Through the ordinance of confirmation, we receive the gift of the Holy Ghost.

† [Feeling the Holy Ghost | The Holy Spirit](#) – Video (3:17) † [Receiving Revelation | The Holy Spirit](#) – Video (4:18)

†7. Elder Dallin H. Oaks

What must we do for the Holy Ghost to be with us continually?

What are some of the functions of the Holy Ghost? †8. Functions of the Holy Ghost (partial list)

Would you or could you share an experience with someone about how the Holy Ghost has blessed you?

5. We must endure to the end in faith to receive eternal life.

- 2 Ne. 31:19-20; D&C 14:7 What does it mean to endure to the end?
- D&C 24:8 How can we remain faithful during afflictions and trials?

Next Week: Lesson 8: The Restoration of the Priesthood; See L8 [Class Member Study Guide](#). † •
(You can download a free LDS Institute Manual at: [Doctrine and Covenants Manual: Religion 324 and 325](#).)

†1. **President David O. McKay:** “Humility is the solid foundation of all the virtues.” (In *Prayers That Bring Miracles*, 24; and in *Christ’s Ideals for Living*, 39)

A Firm Foundation of First Principles & Ordinances

†2. **Richard Neltzel Holzapfel** wrote that when the Saints learned that Johnson’s Army was coming to regulate the Mormons, Brigham Young “had the entire temple [sandstone] foundation covered with dirt so the area would resemble a freshly plowed field...

“[T]he Saints returned to their homes. But the uneasy truce prevented work on the temple for the next two years, until Brigham Young directed the foundation to be uncovered in the spring of 1860. It took **two more years to uncover the foundation... Large cracks were found in the foundation walls.** It was clear that the foundation would never support the temple President Young envisioned. Thus, the **Saints began the arduous task of removing the original stones down to the bottom layer, to be replaced** by better quality [granite] stones cut to fit without mortar... It wasn’t until 1867—nine years after the foundation had been covered with dirt and twenty years after the temple site had been selected—that the temple walls rose above the ground for the first time!” (“[Every Window, Every Spire ‘Speaks of the Things of God’](#),” *Ensign*, Mar. 1993, 7. See also Elder Jeffrey R. Holland, “[However Long and Hard the Road](#),” *New Era*, Sept. 1983, 38 and [Wikipedia: Salt Lake Temple](#).)

†3. **Repentance—Lesson Manual:** “Repentance is a major theme in the Doctrine and Covenants. The Lord teaches the doctrine of repentance and repeatedly emphasizes the need to repent. He promises great blessings to those who repent—and punishments for those who do not.”

†4. **“President Ezra Taft Benson:** “Repentance means more than simply a reformation of behavior... True repentance is based on and flows from faith in the Lord Jesus Christ. There is no other way. True repentance involves a change of heart and not just a change of behavior (see Alma 5:13)” (*The Teachings of Ezra Taft Benson* [1988], 71).

†5. **Elder Neal A. Maxwell:** “For some months, I’ve tried to emphasize repentance, **one of the most vital and merciful doctrines** of the kingdom. It is too little understood, too little applied by us all, as if it were merely a word on a bumper sticker. Since we have been told clearly by Jesus what manner of men and women we ought to become—even as he is (see 3 Ne. 27:27)—how can we do so, except each of us employs repentance as the regular means of personal progression? ... Without it, clearly there could be no ‘perfecting of the Saints.’ (Eph. 4:12.)

...

Repentance is a rescuing, not a dour doctrine. It is available to the gross sinner as well as to the already-good individual striving for incremental improvement.

Repentance requires both turning away from evil and turning to God. (See Deut. 4:30; see also Bible Dictionary, s.v. “Repentance.”) When ‘a mighty change’ is required, full repentance involves a *180-degree turn*, and without looking back! (Alma 5:12-13.) Initially, this turning reflects progress from telestial to terrestrial behavior, and later on to celestial behavior. As the sins of the telestial world are left behind, the focus falls ever more steadily upon the sins of omission, which often keep us from full consecration.” (“[Repentance](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1991, 30).

†6. **Baptism—Lesson Manual:** “Faith and repentance lead to baptism, the first ordinance of the gospel. In the Doctrine and Covenants, the Lord revealed the purposes, qualifications, and instructions for baptism. Through the Prophet Joseph Smith, John the Baptist restored the authority that is necessary to perform this ordinance.”

†7. **Elder Dallin H. Oaks:** “When we consciously and sincerely **renew our baptismal covenants as we partake of the sacrament**, we renew our qualification for the promise ‘that [we] may **always** have his Spirit to be with [us]’ (D&C 20:77).” (“[Always Have His Spirit](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1996, 60).

†8. **Functions of the Holy Ghost (partial list):**

- He is a teacher: D&C 18:18; 39:6; and John 14:26.
- He is the Comforter: D&C 39:6 and John 14:16.
- He is a testifier: D&C 42:17; 100:8 and John 15:26.
- He leads us to do good, walk humbly, and judge righteously: D&C 11:12.
- He enlightens our minds and fills our souls with joy: D&C 11:13; 76:10.
- He sanctifies our souls: D&C 84:33 and 3 Nephi 27:20.
- He inspires us in where to go, what to do, and what to say: D&C 31:11; 75:27; 84:85.

Recommended Reading:

Elder Neal A. Maxwell, “[Repentance](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1991, 30.

Elder Don R. Clarke, “[Blessings of the Sacrament](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 2012, 104.

Elder Dallin H. Oaks, “[Always Have His Spirit](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1996, 60.

Visit www.stephenmbird.com/library/gospel-doctrine †

Further Enrichment Resources:

How to Repent

Jay E. Jensen: “Some years ago I worked in the Missionary Department of the Church. We were developing materials to help missionaries be better and do better. One of the General Authorities shared this experience about repentance:

“ ‘A little over a year ago, I had the privilege of interviewing a young man to go on a mission. Because he had committed a major transgression, it was necessary for him under then-existing policy to be interviewed by a General Authority. When the young man came in, I said, ‘Apparently there’s been a major transgression in your life, and that has necessitated this interview. Would you mind telling me what the problem was? What did you do?’

“ ‘He laughed and said, ‘Well, there isn’t anything I haven’t done.’ I said, ‘Well, let’s be more specific then. Have you ... ?’ And then this General Authority began to probe with some very specific questions. The young man laughed again and said, ‘I told you, I’ve done everything.’

“ ‘I said, ‘How many times have you ...’ He said very sarcastically, ‘Do you think I numbered them?’ I said, ‘I would to God you could if you can’t.’ He said, again quite sarcastically, ‘Well, I can’t.’

“ ‘I said, ‘How about ...’ And then the General Authority probed in another direction. He said, ‘I told you. I’ve done everything.’ I said, ‘Drugs?’ He said, ‘Yes,’ in a very haughty attitude. I said, ‘What makes you think you’re going on a mission then?’ He said, ‘I know I’m going. My patriarchal blessing says I’ll go on a mission, and I’ve repented. I haven’t done any of those things for this past year. I have repented, and I know I’m going on a mission.’

“ ‘I said, ‘My dear friend, I’m sorry but you are not going on a mission. Do you think we could send you out with those clean, wholesome young men who have never violated the code? Do you think we could have you go out and boast and brag about your past? You haven’t repented; you have just stopped doing something.

“ ‘[Sometime in your life you need to visit Gethsemane; and when you have been there, you’ll understand what repentance is.](#) Only after you have suffered in some small degree as the Savior suffered in Gethsemane will you know what repentance is. The Savior has suffered in a way none of us understands for every transgression committed. How dare you laugh and jest and have a haughty attitude about your repentance? I’m sorry, you are not going on a mission.’

“ ‘He started to cry, and he cried for several minutes. I didn’t say a word. Finally, he said, ‘I guess that’s the first time I have cried since I was five years old.’ I said, ‘If you had cried like that the first time you were tempted to violate the moral code, you possibly would be going on a mission.’

“ ‘He left the office, and I think he felt I was really cruel. I explained to the bishop and the stake president that the boy could not go on a mission.’

“About six months later the same General Authority returned to that city to speak in a lecture series held in the evening. When he finished, many young adults lined up to shake hands with him. As he shook hands, one by one, he looked up and saw the young man that he had previously interviewed standing in the line about four back. The General Authority relates the following:

“ ‘My mind quickly flashed back to our interview. I recalled his laughing and haughty attitude. I remembered how sarcastic he was. Pretty soon he was right in front of me. I was on the stand bending over, and as I reached down to shake his hand, I noticed a great change had taken place. He had tears in his eyes. He had almost a holy glow about his countenance. He took my hand in his and said, ‘I’ve been there; I’ve been to Gethsemane and back.’ I said, ‘I know. It shows in your face.’ We can be forgiven for our transgressions, but we must understand that just to stop doing something is not repentance. If it had not been for the Savior and the miracle of forgiveness, this young man would have carried his transgressions throughout all eternity. We ought to love the Savior and serve Him for this reason and this reason alone’ (Elder Vaughn J. Featherstone, Sweden Area Conference, Youth Session, Aug. 1974).” (“[Do You Know How to Repent?](#)” *New Era*, Nov. 1999, 4.)

Endure to the End

Elder Boyd K. Packer: “Our lives are made up of thousands of everyday choices. Over the years these little choices will be bundled together and show clearly what we value.” (“[The Choice](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1980, 20)